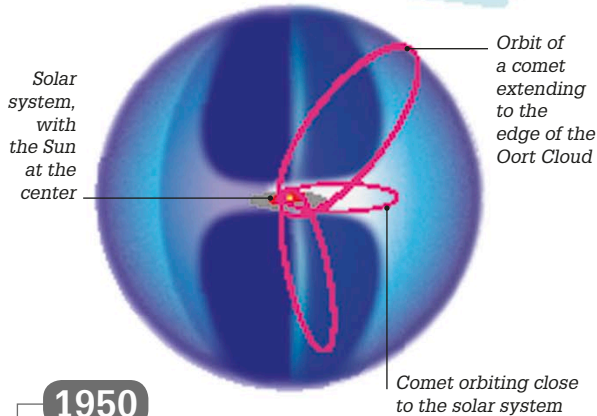


1950 ▶ 1955



1950

Oort Cloud

Dutch astronomer Jan Hendrik Oort suggested that some comets come from a cloud of icy bodies that encircles the very edge of the solar system. This region, now called the Oort Cloud, is believed to lie between 20,000 and 100,000 times further away than Earth's average distance from the Sun.

1951

Ferranti Mark 1

The Ferranti Mark 1 became the first computer to be available for sale, delivered to Manchester University, UK, ahead of Univac 1 computers in the US. The Mark 1 could perform 600 ten-digit multiplications in three seconds and was used for research. It also ran the first chess-playing program and its "hoot" command made it one of the first computers to play sound.



1950

1950

Treating leukaemia

American pharmacologists Gertrude Elion and George Hitchings developed thioguanine—the first successful drug to help treat leukemia, a cancer of blood-forming tissues. The pair developed another drug, 6-MP, the following year, which is still used to treat leukemia today.

1952

First hydrogen bomb

The first hydrogen bomb was tested at Enewetak Atoll in the Marshall Islands (then under US control). The bomb, nicknamed "Ivy Mike," left a crater 164 ft (50 m) deep and 1,180 miles (1,900 km) wide, and sent a 25-mile- (40-km-) high mushroom cloud up into the atmosphere.

1952

Barcodes

American inventors Bernard Silver and Norman Woodland patented the barcode—a series of lines that is scanned and converted into a unique number, which identifies a product. The technology was not introduced until much later, in 1974.



Scanner uses a laser to read the pattern of lines representing a long number

Rising mushroom cloud from the "Ivy Mike" hydrogen bomb test



1953

Flight recorder invented

The modern "black box" flight recorder was created by Australian inventor David Warren. It recorded flight instrument readings as well as voices in the aircraft's cockpit to help experts analyze crashes and air incidents.